

Multiple Redundancies

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Traditionally, the process of backing up valuable data has been glossed over, probably because of the absence of affordable storage and the lack of easy-to-use software. However, this doesn't apply today, when you have storage available at dirt-cheap prices as well as great software—some of which are free. Such software has a plethora of features that enable you to set up a backup system once, and then forget about it; and they are suitable both for individuals and businesses.

If you're convinced about the necessity of data backups, you need to sit back and understand your requirements. The frequency of generation of data will determine your choice of software, as there are some upper limits to how frequently you can back up. Likewise with issues of retrieving older copies: some software allow you to store multiple versions of the same files, while others overwrite older versions and keep only the latest version in storage.

Data backup methods have evolved over the years. Until about a few years ago, most SoHos used the older and cheaper way of data backup—optical media (CD / DVD). But though CDs and/or DVDs are still useful for one-time backups, they can be a pain in the neck when regular backups are needed. More user-friendly storage would be external USB hard drives. Many drives feature the “one-touch backup” option; they come with software that automatically backs up data at the press of a button.

File backup, on the other hand, is the conventional copy-and-paste (rather, copy and burn to storage media). The software copies the selected files on demand, or on a predetermined schedule. This is fast, and is suitable even when you install new hardware. The problem with file backup is that if and when the OS crashes, you will have to start installing everything—Windows, device drivers, and your software, before you can use the data. Then again, there is the chance that you might just forget to back up an important new document because it wasn't in the usual source folder for the backup software.

A third type of backup solution is offsite, online-based backup. For a price, storage companies allow you to automatically back up data to their servers. This works well if you have a broadband connection. Online backup is file-based; it takes less time, and less space is utilised because only the data is copied (without any settings).

When it comes to software, customers have a number of choices based on budget and requirements. Data backup and recovery software comes in both paid and free versions. We'll look at both categories.

This is Symantec's data recovery software; it falls in the image backup segment. It costs \$69.99 (Rs 2,800); find a free evaluation copy on this month's DVD. Norton Ghost works on Windows and does a comprehensive backup of your hard drive. You can also back up individual files and folders. Restoration is as easy as clicking a button. However, it is a resource hog. Ghost analyses your hard drive when you start it, so startup times depend on the amount of data on your hard disk(s).

Some options with Norton Ghost are the scheduling of backups and use of password protection on the backed up files. It creates periodic restore points, like System Restore does in Windows. Norton Ghost does not need to be running for a scheduled backup to start: it will start all by itself. It even allows

